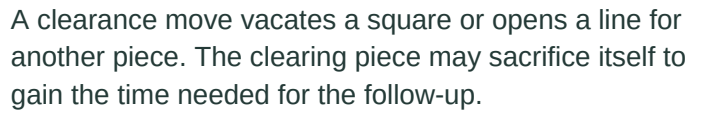


Clearance tactics

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: queen on c7. Check for tactical protection.

Previous move: 23...c5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

24. Re8+ Nf8 25. Rxa8 Bxa8 26. Re8

24.Re8+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. From e8 it attacks king on h8 and rook on a8. Recorded reply: **24...Nf8**.

25.Rxa8 The rook captures the rook on a8. Recorded reply: **25...Bxa8**.

26.Re8 The rook moves from e1 to e8. From e8 it attacks knight on f8 and bishop on a8.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 23 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from -2 to -2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.